

The Sleeping Garden

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being kind and full of ideas.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only new ideas to try.*

Before you begin

This morning you wake up and the whole island is quiet. Too quiet. You look out of the window of the House of the Little Mages. The Great Garden is grey and still, as if it has fallen asleep. The flowers are shut. The fountain makes no sound.

You are two little mages. You pick up your bag. You look at each other. "Let us go and wake it up," you say together. The golden path is waiting.

★ *What is your mage name? Which magic do you choose: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?*

Stop 1 The Vine Gate

You come to a tall gate. Green vines have tied it shut with a big knot of leaves. The gate will not open.

A soft grey cat steps out of the mist. It is the Mist Cat. It purrs and looks at the knot, then at you. It seems to want to help.

★ *How do you open the way? Could a magic make a gap? Could you ask the vines kindly to move? Try something and see.*

When the gate swings open, the first sleepy flower opens one petal. The garden is waking, just a little.

Stop 2 The Flower Bed

Now you reach a bed of flowers. Four of them have drooped and lost their order. A tiny voice hums a little rhyme: "First the sun, then the sea, then the berry, then fly free."

The flowers want to stand in the right colours, but they have forgotten how.

★ *Which colour is the sun? Which is the sea? Can you set the four flowers in the order the rhyme sings?*

When the flowers stand in their order, they open wide and turn their faces up. Two more corners of the garden turn green again.

Stop 3 The Talking Fountain

You come to a stone fountain. It is not singing. It is not even dripping. The water sits still and grey, and the fountain looks a little sad. You lean close. "Hello?" you whisper. The fountain sighs. It wants to feel happy again.



What could you do to cheer it up? Maybe a song. Maybe a joke. Maybe a kind word. What do you try?

When the fountain feels happy, the water leaps up and sparkles. It begins to sing again. Now only the very heart of the garden is still asleep.

The Heart of the Garden

At the centre of the garden you find a small, sad sprite curled up tight. It was the sprite who sent the garden to sleep. Not to be unkind. It was only lonely, and it did not know how to ask for a friend.

There is no fight here. There never was a real villain.



What do you say to the sprite? How can you show it that it is not alone?

When you offer the sprite your friendship, it smiles for the first time in a long while. All around you, the Great Garden wakes up at once: flowers open, the fountain sings, and the island is bright and warm again.

You did it together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas. Well done.

The Sleeping Garden: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure (a building-brick minifigure works well) on the Start.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the objects that come up (a key, a flower, a bridge) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Light and Voice, say, or Grow and Change, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly flutters past and gives you one free hint.

2	You find a glimmer of energy: take back one energy star.
3	A kindly breeze: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	A wise creature lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	A little song drifts by and everyone dances for one happy turn.

How it ends

The Heart of the Garden is not a battle. The "antagonist" is the Lonely Sprite, who sent the garden to sleep only because it wanted a friend. The adventure is won when the children offer it friendship. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the heart, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Sleeping Garden: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Vine Gate (Easy)

The challenge. The gate is tied shut by a thick knot of vines and will not open on its own.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can solve this:

- **Grow** a gap in the vines, or grow a vine staircase over the gate.
- **Change** the knot into something looser, or into a key for the latch.
- **Voice:** ask the vines politely to unwind and step aside.
- **Light** can reveal a hidden catch that, once seen, is easy to undo.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat nudges a loose vine to show where to start, then the players spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish. Nobody waits at this gate for long.

Stop 2: The Flower Bed (Normal)

The challenge. Four flowers have lost their order. A small voice hums the clue: "First the sun, then the sea, then the berry, then fly free." The players must set the four flowers in the right colours.

Solution. Each line is a colour:

- "the sun" = **yellow**
- "the sea" = **blue**
- "the berry" = **red**
- "fly free" (off into the clouds) = **white**

So the order is **yellow, blue, red, white**. Build or place four flowers in that order. Logic and a little vocabulary do the work here, not a magic.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, read the rhyme again slowly, one line at a time, and let them place one flower per line. Getting there with help still counts as a full success, and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Talking Fountain (Normal)

The challenge. The fountain has gone quiet and sad and will not flow. It does not need fixing; it needs cheering.

Intended solution. This is a **Voice** moment. The players speak to the fountain and lift its mood: sing it a song, tell it a joke, or offer a few kind words. Any genuine attempt to cheer it should work. Light (a warm glow) or a combined magic is a fine alternative.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the fountain ask a tiny question of its own ("Do you know any songs about water?") to give them a thread to pull. The moment they try, let the water leap and sing.

The Heart of the Garden (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. The players find the **Lonely Sprite** curled up at the centre. It sent the garden to sleep because it was lonely and did not know how to ask for a friend.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, an invitation to play, a promise to visit. There is no fight and no trick. When they offer friendship, the sprite smiles and the whole garden wakes at once. End on that warmth. The children have won by being kind and full of ideas, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 8.4, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.